

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
Growing Up - How to...be good*

July 20th, 2025



"Oarsmen"
By Gustave Caillebotte, 1877

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Guest Organist

A Trumpet Tune - Frederick Swann (1931-2022)
Roulade - Seth Bingham (1882-1972)
Adoration - Florence Price (1887-1953)
Petite Promenade - Dale Wood (1934-2003)
Rubrics: A Liturgical Suite - Dan Locklair (b. 1949)
I. "...‘Hallelujah,’ has been restored..."
II. "Silence may be kept."
III. "...and thanksgivings may follow."
IV. "The Peace may be exchanged."
V. "The people respond – Amen!"

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Yulia Fox

Anointed by the morning light
we lift our spirits to receive
the gift of this new day.
Open our eyes, O God,
*to the beauty that surrounds us
as we walk through this day
with an awareness
that calls forth grateful living.*

In all of creation
let us see the brightness of your face.
Shine in our hearts and on our lives,
filling us with joy, creativity, laughter, and hope.
*Draw us into the radiant glory of your presence
and give us the courage to live lives
filled with your beauty.*

Call forth our joy to greet the dawn
and help us to rejoice
in the marrow of our bones.
Help us to rejoice
from the center of our souls.
Help us to rejoice
in our heart of hearts.
Help us to rejoice
from the depths of our bodies.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Praise to God, the World's Creator

ODE TO JOY

Praise to God, the world's creator,
Source of life and growth and breath,
Cradling in her arms her children,
Holding them from birth to death.
In our bodies, in our living,
Strength and truth of all we do,
God is present, working with us,
Making us creators too.

Praise to God our saving Wisdom,
Meeting us with love and grace,
Helping us to grow in wholeness,
Giving freedom, room, and space.
In our hurting, in our risking,
In the thoughts we dare not name,
God is present, growing with us,
Healing us from fear and shame.

Praise to God, the Spirit in us,
Prompting hidden depths of prayer,
Firing us to long for justice,
Reaching out with tender care.
In our searching, in our loving,
In our struggles to be free,
God is present, living in us,
Pointing us to what shall be. [adapt/jberry]

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Creator God,
with joyful praise
we receive the light of this new day,
light born from the earth's turning.

In this, our sacred time,
let us feel the healing of your morning rays
as we lift our faces toward
the splendor of your creation
and help us - to become a prayer for this day.

*In the soft glory of this new day,
let us taste the joy of being awake
and let your face shine on us
that we may in turn shine on others.* [adapt/mwiederkehr]

For this we pray.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Jesus, Lover Of My Soul"
Cathedral Choir

JOSEPH PARRY

***The Lord's Prayer**

Yulia Fox

*Our God, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

We are invited this morning
to open our hearts to the healing light
of God's encircling presence.
We are invited this morning
to open our eyes to the opportunities this day has to offer.

We ask that we will be surprised with small joys
and pieces of beauty scattered through the hours
and that the beautiful presence of God
will help us this day,
to taste the joy that peace
with God and with each other
can bring.

This morning, may the Heart and Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Yulia Fox

from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 15

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Music for Meditation

"We Will Arise"

BIRGID TÄHT AND MARI VALJATAGA

Please sing with the Cathedral Choir

I open my heart to hear your heart,
I open my ears to hear your voice,
I open my eyes to see your eyes,
Together with love we will arise.

I open my mind to hear your mind,
I open my words to hear your words,
May peace and joy be yours and mine;
Together with love we will arise.

Prayer of Our Hearts

O Living Breath of God,
O Morning Song of Love,
O you in whom we live and move
and have our being!

Silence

Perhaps, O God, we have been asleep too long.
We ask this morning for
healing in the *unseeing* part of our lives.
Lead us to our awakening places.
Awaken us to the new light.

Silence

Open the doors of our hearts,
as well as the windows of our souls,
and the walls of our minds.
Awaken us to hope.
Awaken us to joy.
Awaken us to love.
Awaken us to new insights.

Silence

In this, our sacred time,
make our hearts ready to receive
the brightness of your presence
and give us the courage to live
into who we truly are. [adapt/miederkehr]
This we pray.
Amen and Amen.

Sermon

Rev. Tanaka Pack

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Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"If I Should Fall Behind"
Laude

BRUCE SPRINGSTEEN, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Yulia Fox

Holy One,
we give thanks to you for our life
and the courage we are given to live it.
On this day and all the days to come –
let us be brave
as we express our gratitude for this life with our generosity;
as we continue to let our faith be expressed in works of peace and justice;
and as we make our belief in the future find full expression
in the ways we love,
and care for each other.

May it be so.
May it be so on this day, and in all the days to come.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

The world we go into is a world filled with challenges, with crises, with pain, with disappointment. We go as people who know these things intimately because we have felt them, experienced them, and railed against them.

Yet, we also go now as those who would see not only what the world is, but what we can make it be.

*In these days – and in all the days to come –
may our hands, our hearts, and our voices
be turned toward making it so!*

Go in peace
In peace!
Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

“Arise, Shine”
Cathedral Choir

JAEBON HWANG

*Hymn for the Journey *Arise, Shine Out, Your Light Has Come*

THE GIFT OF LOVE

Arise, shine out, your light has come,
Unfolding city of our dreams.
On distant hills a glory gleams:
The new creation has begun.

Above earth's valleys, thick with night,
High on your walls the dawn appears,
And history shall dry all its tears,
As nations stream towards your light.

The sounds of violence shall cease
As dwellings of salvation rise
To sparkle in eternal skies
From avenues of praise and peace.

The dancing air shall glow with light,
And sun and moon give up their place,
When love shines out of every face,
Our good, our glory, and delight.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*
Toccata - John Weaver (1937-2021)

Inside The Music

"Jaebon wrote "Arise, Shine" as one of a three part set of short pieces for services at FCCLA. We've enjoyed singing them in the past, and are excited to get to sing this one with her. There's a special joy to hearing the composer's aural insight into their own work. This short, punchy setting of Isaiah 60 projects a wholeness in its complex and rapidly shifting harmonies. Each measure has an expression of D major and D minor. The two modes move back and forth so fast that the ear begins to stretch to receive its fullness of harmony. In only 17 measures she includes all 12 notes of the chromatic scale. She does so in a way that features their unique contribution to the sonic world she brought into being. The well known text says that "thy light has come." One reading of it speaks to each individual, calling us to come into ourselves and recognize the divinity flowing through us all. Uniqueness within diversity can be a difficult understanding to relate to. The Prodigal Son story reminds us that we are all different. We make different decisions. Sometimes those decisions cause the group to thrive, and sometimes they cause static. We often find that we want to judge one another by an equal measure. Yet, we remain unique within the whole. How do we come to appreciate each other, and ourselves, as different members within the unified whole? Bruce Springsteen said that his "If I Fall Behind" is one of his favorite pieces by his own pen. Although it was originally written for his wife on the occasion of their wedding, I love how easily it speaks to this particular aspect of being human. The song pivots on two ideas. The first says that we have dedicated ourselves to each other, and reminds us that our individuality can sometimes get in the way of togetherness. The second idea affirms that in those moments where we are more separate, we can and will leave room for each other to grow into our common space. In his words: "I'll wait for you, and if I fall behind, wait for me." The melody is tender and arcs in broad waves that feel as if they are always settling. Singing it feels like trying to keep a leaf in the air with wind generated from your hands. That is kind of what it feels like to me to be in community with others. Thriving community involves giving space for people to shine as themselves while contributing a little wind to everyone's sails. Importantly, it also involves receiving enough wind for yourself to keep going." – Dr. David Harris